Spencer Kiser

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Engineering manager. I lead the team that builds and runs The Met's website and APIs. Most of my career has been getting data out of systems that were built to hold it, and to the people who need it, inside the organization and out. I manage six developers and a QA engineer. I came to software through sound and interactive media.

EXPERIENCE

The Metropolitan Museum of Art — New York, 2014 – present

Senior Manager, Application Development — 2021 – present

- Own the back-end and DevOps budget.
- Moved metmuseum.org off an internally hosted CMS and onto Next.js, Sanity, Vercel, and Elasticsearch, section by section rather than in one cutover.
- Led the team that shipped semantic search for the collection in 2026, and hired the developer who led it.
- Now building a new museum-wide API.
- Changed how the team builds: containerized development, automated testing, CI/CD, monitoring, and domain modeling before implementation.

Lead Developer, Collection — 2016 – 2021

- Led the team that built the data layer under the Met's collection: ETL pipelines from the collection management system, and the APIs serving metmuseum.org, the Timeline of Art History, in-gallery screens, and the public.
- Helped define and implement Open Access, which released the collection's metadata and public-domain images under CC0. The public API has served over 900 million requests as of mid-2026.
- Took collection object pages from over 11 seconds to under 3, worldwide. Built a IIIF image server that generates derivatives on demand. Go, Python, Postgres.
- Established test- and documentation-driven development and agile planning across the Digital department.

Manager of Media Technology — 2014 – 2016

- Started the Met's first native app team, behind The Met App, the audio guide, and in-gallery kiosks.
- Replaced hand-maintained content in a licensed system with an automated Python and Postgres pipeline, which let us retire the license and save tens of thousands a year.
- Sunset the product line to build the data layer it was missing, which became the foundation for the collection APIs.
- Introduced agile and test-driven development on the team, then paired with thoughtbot to add capacity and design thinking.

Museum of Modern Art — New York, 2007 – 2014

Media Technology Developer

- Built MoMA's first mobile app on iOS, Android, and mobile web, and the API behind it, from prototype to production. Grew from sole developer to part of a larger team, including a stretch pairing with Pivotal Labs.
- Replatformed moma.org from PHP and MSSQL to Ruby on Rails and Postgres, on hardware we ran ourselves. Built the calendar, ticketing, publications, and a custom CMS for editorial staff.
- Built in-gallery interactives for exhibitions, from a Raspberry Pi gallery door to a hardware Tetris controller.

Earlier

- **WNYC**, Interactive Media Consultant, 2006 – 2007
- **AV&C**, Special Projects Technologist, 2006 – 2007. Gallery interactives, including Mythic Creatures at the American Museum of Natural History.
- **ASCAP**, Business Analyst, Licensing, 2001 – 2005; Team Lead, International Distribution, 1996 – 2001. Built the reporting application account managers used to collect broadcast license fees.

WRITING AND TALKS

- "Connecting to art," *Increment*, 2020, with Jennie Choi
- "Celebrating Three Years of Open Access at The Met," *Perspectives*, The Met, 2020, with Sofie Andersen
- "AI comes to the museum," panel, Aboard, New York, 2026
- Open Access collection data for machine learning research, Fine-Grained Visual Categorization workshops at CVPR, 2019 and 2023
- Museum Computer Network, 2013 and 2015; Museums and the Web, 2017

EDUCATION AND TEACHING

- **New York University**, M.P.S., Interactive Telecommunications Program (ITP), 2006. Later taught Communications Lab there.
- **Boston University**, B.A., German Language and Literature, including an exchange year at Universität Heidelberg
- **The New School**, Audio Engineering Certificate, 2000

SKILLS

Leadership: engineering management, hiring, budget, agile and test-driven practice, vendor partnerships

Architecture: APIs, ETL and data pipelines, cloud migration, search, open data and IIIF

Stacks my teams have run: Next.js, Sanity, Vercel, Elasticsearch, Go, Python, Postgres, Ruby on Rails

Languages: English, German (fluent)